

Pregnancy choices

Deciding what to do about an unexpected pregnancy can be stressful and scary. There are three main options, each with its own advantages and disadvantages.

SEE ALSO[◀ 198–199 Healthy relationships](#)[◀ 224–225 Sex](#)[◀ 228–229 Sexual reproduction](#)[◀ 238–239 Pregnancy](#)

Having choices

Whether a pregnancy is planned or unexpected, there's always a lot to think about. Deciding what to do might depend on personal values and financial circumstances, as well as study and career plans. Some people decide immediately. Others take more time. Many young women find it helpful to discuss their options with their parents, as well as with their partner. Understanding the options available, and the impact of becoming a parent, can help with the decision-making process.

MYTH BUSTER

The truth about pregnancy decisions

Keeping the baby doesn't have to ruin your future. Having and raising a child takes love, commitment, and hard work. Support and childcare aid from a partner and family helps. Many young parents have full lives, continue their education, and go on to build rewarding careers.

Deciding during your pregnancy to give a baby up for adoption is not final. Nothing is finalized until after the baby is born.

Terminating a pregnancy doesn't mean you can't get pregnant in the future. The risk of being unable to have a baby following a termination is extremely low.

Adopting and fostering

Adoption is when a baby is found new parents who bring it up as their own. After the baby is born, it might be briefly placed into foster care before going to live with those new parents. Adoption is a formal legal arrangement and once the process is completed, it can't be reversed.

Open adoption

- There is some ongoing contact between the birth parents and the adoptive family, ranging from a yearly update to regular visits.
- The identity of the adoptive parents is known to the birth parents.

Closed adoption

- There is no ongoing contact between the birth parents and the adoptive family.
- The identity of the new family is kept totally secret.

Fostering

- The baby (or child) goes to live with a different family temporarily. This may happen if the birth parents don't have enough support or are unable to look after the baby.

